Individual Essay - Analysis of Clue, Reproductive Health Application
De Binder, J.

1. Background

Reproductive health apps are becoming more common in today's digital world, where they provide the users to track their menstrual cycle, fertility and even pregnancy. It is not uncommon for these categories of apps to state that they bring empowerment to the user (Clue, 2023), return the power or other words that can be associated with the feminist movement (Alaattinoğlu, 2022). This can be argued to be true, as the applications can provide insight into the biological functions of the female body to the user. These insights can also be argued to empower women, as the application provides guidance based on the users data and thus agency to them to make their own choices. This does however raise the issue of if and how these applications provide the presented experience for the user. This is an interesting problem as there are cases where the design of the applications caused a public backlash due to the design not being inclusive enough, based on non-holistic norms and values regarding gender and sexuality (Lupton, 2015; Sharon, 2017). Also, there has been the case when applications of this kind share data with larger companies for the sake of profit (Schechner and Secada, 2019). The pursuit of making a profit may be relevant to the topic of female empowerment, as it can pose an obstacle if functions are behind a paywall and thus limits the promised experience for the user.

Given the potential benefits and concerns of reproductive health apps, it is of value to examine how these apps are designed and whether they provide empowerment for the users. In this paper, the reproductive health application Clue will be examined.

This prompts the following research question;
- What are the design features and functionality of the reproductive health application Clue that have the potential to empower women regarding their reproductive health.

2. Method section

With the aim to answer the research question stated in this paper, the following methods were put to use. The goal was to examine the design features and functionality of the application Clue. The App Walkthrough Method was employed with the aim to systematically review the application Clue. This meant exploring each of the application's features and functions in a structured manner (Light et al. 2018), taking note of how they work, the accessibility and how they might add onto or lessen female empowerment. All of this data was added into a table with four columns, the purpose was to methodically note down anything relevant (Appendix, Table 1). Two separate tables were added, where it is described how the ranking system regarding accessibility and empowerment is clarified (Appendix, Table 1.1, 1.2). In addition to this, another table was created where every function available in the application was listed. Every function in the table also has a row describing if it was free or required payment from the user (Appendix, Table 2). This helped to identify potential barriers for users to utilize the application to the fullest.

Finally, the talk-aloud method was used to capture the author's thoughts and impressions while the interaction with the application was conducted. This approach allowed for deeper understanding, and later reflection of the potential impact of the application’s design features

and functionality(Appendix, Table 3). Together, these methods aimed to provide a comprehensive understanding of the design features and functionality of the application Clue and the potential impact on female empowerment.

3. Analysis section

The Clue application that has been examined is primarily a menstrual cycle tracking application. There are other so-called modes, such as pregnancy and fertilization tracking, but they are unavailable in the free version. The research question in this paper focuses on the design features and the functionality and how it ties together with the potential to empower women regarding their reproductive health. To find an answer to this, a systematic review of the application was conducted using the methods described in the method chapter. The results of this step-by-step review will be discussed in below subchapters.

3.1 Design Features and Functionality of the Clue App

As stated in the research question, the focus is on the design features and the functionality and how it ties together with the potential to empower women regarding their reproductive health. The application is primarily a menstrual cycle tracking app, and it provides an array of features in the pursuit of filling that role. It contains a calendar, a graphical interface overviewing the current cycle, an analysis page containing statistics based on the user's input (Appendix, Image 1, 4, 5). It has a content page where the user can learn more about relevant areas such as the body, sexuality, biological processes, and reproductive health complications (Appendix, Image 6). It aims to utilize some of these features with the help of the user, by gathering their data (Appendix, Image 2). There are a total of five major categories when it comes to the data gathering, which are the following; bleeding, wellbeing, body, activities and medicinal. These five categories together consist of 33 subcategories, which themselves contain between one up to 12 options to choose from (Appendix, Table 1). The large amount of options that the user is presented with have in previous research been commented on. This is a direct quote from the paper written by Healy (2021), “the app had more intimate knowledge of my reproductive behavior than my husband or doctor”. The quote does raise the question if all the options provided to the user are necessary for the application to fulfill its purpose.

The majority of the features and functions provided by the application are available to the user on the free version, but it was unclear to the author how they were functionally used in the analytics part. As noted through the systematic review of the application, Clue Plus, which is obtained through a monthly subscription, provides insight into unique patterns in the user's cycle and experiences (Appendix, Table 2). This seems to indicate that the free version does not provide the same insight. The content page previously mentioned contains several areas as a tool for educating users, but the actual content is unavailable in the free version.
Table 1 presents the two different ranks for features and functions, including their accessibility and empowerment rankings, as described in more detail in tables 1.1 and 1.2.

3.2 The Talk-Aloud method

In the step-by-step review that was conducted when examining the application Clue, a talk-aloud method was simultaneously done. These are the main takeaways, for a closer inspection view the appendix, table 2.

Application starts with encouraging words, that the user can now live synced with their menstrual cycle. Advertisement was displayed after registering the account, suggesting the user to try out the premium version of the application by using a seven days free trial. It was hard to find where to close the advertisement. After logging in, the first thing the author noticed was the advertisement at the top (Appendix, Image 1). When proceeding to use the feature of tracking the menstrual cycle, the large number of options were somewhat overwhelming and possibly worrying considering the level of detail that was possible.

The reason it was worrying was because many of the options did not seem to be relevant for the analytics part, but perhaps for journaling - which does provide agency and thus empowerment for the users. An example is the question regarding menstrual protection, where the user can pick from which type of product is used for that day. That can be argued not to be relevant for the analytics as it should not alter the biological processes, but it can also be argued to be useful for the user themselves as a form of journaling. It stood out to the author, and it was suspected to be more of a way to gather data that can be sold to advertisers but it can be that the author is cynical. If the user navigates to their profile, and from there into privacy settings, they will discover two activated slide buttons. The first one is of primary interest, and here is what it said which is a direct quote from the application - “Advertisement purposes such as tracking or retargeting”.

This seems a bit worrying, considering that the Clue Plus advertisement states that they do not sell the users data. Regarding the Clue Plus advertisement, it may also be that the free trial of seven days leads to a 12 month subscription. This has not been confirmed by the author, but it seems to be indicated by the design, as the 7-days trial period encapsulates the 12 month subscription option (Appendix, Image 9).

3.2 Facilitators and Barriers for Female Empowerment

The concept of female empowerment has been a central theme throughout this paper, as it relates to the research question and the application’s intended message. The primary focus has been on examining if the application supports female empowerment and how it achieves this goal. In the context of the application, female empowerment is defined as the ability to provide and be returned with power that by its nature supports insight into making informed decisions. As presented in the appendix, the majority of the features provided by the application have been ranked as either empowering or neutral. This was a thought-provoking process, as two arguments arose during this process.

The first argument is regarding if the application needs the data that the user can provide, to fulfill the core function of menstrual cycle tracking and the connected analytics of that service. At one hand, it can be disempowering for the user as they might be presented with alternatives that are intrusive. It can be argued that it is not relevant for the application to know if the user masturbates by use of sex toys or their hands (Appendix, Table 1). But the other side of it, as mentioned with journaling, is that the overview of the data provided can provide insight for future decisions.

The second argument is again, regarding the applications features to be provided data. The example regarding sex, the usage of sex toys or similar can set an unwelcome standard for some users as it might be unpleasant or a sensitive subject depending on lifestyle. Again, it can be argued to be empowering due to the agency given to the user to live their life. But it

can also be argued to provide an unwelcome influence on what can be seen or develop into unhealthy behavior for the user.

Based on above arguments, the choice to rank features based on if they support female empowerment proved tricky. Furthermore, it is commendable for the designers to provide a design that is inclusive based on the many options available. For example, in the medicinal option the choice of choosing testosterone treatment is included. Based on the author's opinion, it does seem that a wide array of users were included during the design but another remark is that it seems to have cultural values of the western world. The application has the potential to support female empowerment, but this should be done in a responsible manner that respects the user's agency and privacy.

4. Conclusion section

The research question of this paper is "What are the design features and functionality of the reproductive health application Clue that have the potential to empower women regarding their reproductive health." Worth to mention is that this study was subject to limitations that should be acknowledged. Firstly, every method was conducted by a single author, which may have introduced some bias into the analysis. Secondly, the author is male, which may have affected the interpretation of what features facilitate or act as a barrier for female empowerment. Lastly, the examination of the Clue application was limited to the free version, which restricts what features can be explored.

Despite this, the paper aims to provide an unbiased understanding of the design features and functionality of the Clue application and its potential impact on female empowerment. The App Walkthrough Method was employed to systematically review the Clue application. This involved exploring the application, seeking each feature and function in a structured manner, noting down how they work, their accessibility, and how it might facilitate or act as a barrier for female empowerment. The data collected from this review was added to a table with four columns. Two additional tables were created to either list all functions available and whether it was free or not, and data generated by the talk-aloud method.

Future research can build upon these findings and further examine Clue Plus, to understand how the data can be used to support female empowerment, as well as explore other reproductive health apps that promise empowerment and review if they do deliver this promise.

5. References

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6. Appendix

Feature	Function	Accessibility	Empowerment
Mode: Track your menstruation	Predict the timing and duration of menstrual cycle	Difficult	Empowering
Mode: Track your fertilization	Not available	N/A	Empowering
Mode: Track your pregnancy	Not available	N/A	Empowering
Register an account	Registers the account	Easy	Empowering

	by entering a name, email, password.		
Track your menstruation flow; choose between light to very heavy	Record the user's menstrual cycle and flow intensity	Easy	Empowering
Track the spotting; red or brown	Record the occurrence of spotting and its color	Easy	Neutral
Track your emotions; happy, sad, sensitive, angry, confident, excited, annoyed, insecure, grateful, neutral	Record the user's emotional state on a daily basis	Easy	Empowering
Track your pain; pain free, menstrual pain, ovulation, sensitive breasts, headache, migraine, migraine with aura, lumbar spine, legs, joints, vulva.	Record the user's pain level and location	Easy	Empowering
Track your sleep; the amount of hours and minutes	Record the user's sleep duration and quality	Easy	Empowering
Track your sexlife; Protected intercourse, unprotected intercourse, intercourse that stopped, no intercourse today, high sex drive, low sex drive, masturbation, sextoys, orgasm, no orgasm, fantasies, painful intercourse	Record the user's sexual activity and experiences	Easy	Empowering
Track your energy; exhausted, tired, okay, alert, very alert	Record the user's energy level on a daily basis	Easy	Empowering
Track if you have; PMS	Record the user's	Easy	Empowering

	premenstrual symptoms		
Track the type of menstrual protection used; tampon, menstrual pad, underwear protection, menstrual cup, period panties	Record the user's preferred menstrual protection method	Easy	Neutral
Track your mood; Calm, stressed, focused, absent-minded, motivated, unmotivated, creative, productive, unproductive	Record the user's mood on a daily basis	Easy	Empowering
Track your social behavior; Social, pulled back, encouraging, confrontative	Record the user's social behavior on a daily basis	Easy	Empowering
Track your cravings; Sweet, sour, fatty, spicy, carbohydrates	Record the user's food cravings on a daily basis	Easy	Empowering
Track your discharges; none, sticky, creamy, egg white, atypical	Record the user's vaginal discharge and its consistency	Easy	Empowering
Track your skin; Ok, good, acne, dry, fat, itchy	Record the user's skin condition on a daily basis	Easy	Empowering
Track your hair; Okay hair-day, good hair-day, bad hair-day, fat scalp, dry scalp, hair loss	Record the user's hair condition on a daily basis	Easy	Empowering
Track your weight; Input your weight in kilograms.	Record the user's weight on a regular basis	Easy	Empowering
Track your digestion; Okay, swollen, gassy, throat burn, nauseous,	Allow the user to record digestive health and provide insights into	Easy	Empowering

vomiting	patterns over time.		
Track your stool; Okay, constipated, diarrhea	Allow the user to record bowel movements and provide insights into patterns over time.	Easy	Empowering
Track your temperature; Input your bodily temperature in celsius	Input your bodily temperature in celsius and track it over time.	Easy	Empowering
Track your workout; Running, swimming, yoga, biking, walking, pilates, weightlifting, stretching, kegels, rest day	Log your physical activity, including running, swimming, yoga, biking, walking, pilates, weightlifting, stretching, kegels, and rest days. Monitor progress and set goals.	Easy	Empowering
Track your meditation; Input the hours and minutes	Log your meditation practice, including the duration and frequency. Use this to build a mindfulness routine and track progress over time.	Easy	Empowering
Track your freetime; Free, traveling, date	Log your free time activities, including travel and social events. Use this to manage stress and ensure that you are prioritizing self-care.	Easy	Empowering

Track your partying; Alcohol, cigarettes, wild night, hungover	Log your partying habits, including alcohol and cigarette consumption, wild nights out, and hangovers. Use this to monitor your health and wellness.	Easy	Empowering
Track your pregnancy or ovulation tests; Negative pregnancy, positive pregnancy, negative ovulation, positive ovulation test.	Log the results of pregnancy and ovulation tests. Use this to track fertility and plan for pregnancy.	Easy	Empowering
Track your medical appointments; Gynecologist, Gynecologists cell sample, test for STDs, general checkup, vaccination	Log medical appointments, including gynecologist visits, STD tests, and general checkups. Use this to stay on top of your health and wellness.	Easy	Empowering
Track your medicine use; Painkillers, antihistamines, antibiotics, sickness or the flu, estrogen treatment, progesterone treatment, testosterone treatment, last minute contraceptive pill	Log the use of medications, including painkillers, antihistamines, antibiotics, and hormone treatments. Use this to manage chronic conditions and stay on top of medication schedules.	Easy	Empowering
Track your cramps; Sickness or flu, allergies, fever, UTI, STD	Log symptoms related to cramps, including sickness or flu, allergies, fever, UTI,	Easy	Empowering

	and STD. Use this to manage pain and monitor overall health.		
Track your contraceptive pill; Taken, missed, late, double dosage, no pill or placebo	Log contraceptive pill use, including missed, late, double dosage, or no pill/placebo use. Use this to manage birth control and ensure proper usage.	Easy	Empowering
Track your hormonal IUD; Controlled thread, inserted, removed	Log the insertion and removal of a hormonal IUD, including checking the IUD thread. Use this to monitor birth control and manage any potential side effects.	Easy	Empowering
Track your contraceptive -injection; Taken	Log contraceptive injection use. Use this to manage birth control and ensure proper usage.	Easy	Empowering
Track your contraceptive implant; inserted, removed	Log the insertion and removal of a contraceptive implant. Use this to monitor birth control and manage any potential side effects.	Easy	Empowering
Track your contraceptive-patch; Placed, removed, placed	Log the placement and removal of a	Easy	Empowering

late, removed late	contraceptive patch, including instances of late placement/removal. Use this to monitor birth control and ensure proper usage.		
Track your contraceptive-ring; Placed, removed, placed late, removed late	Log the placement and removal of a contraceptive ring, including instances of late placement/removal. Use this to monitor birth control and ensure proper usage.	Easy	Empowering
Graphical display showing; how many days left of the cycle, when the next one will be, when the predicted ovulation will occur and when the user is most fertile	Display a visual representation of menstrual cycles, including days left in the cycle, next menstruation date, predicted ovulation, and fertile days. Use this to track fertility and manage birth control.	Easy	Empowering
Settings; gain access to Support, Legal and Privacy Settings	Access support, legal, and privacy settings. Use this to manage app preferences and get help with any issues.	Medium	Empowering
Calendar; Displays different colors that symbolize different aspects of reproductive health such as menstruation and ovulation for example	Display a color-coded calendar of menstrual cycles, including menstruation and ovulation dates. Use this to track fertility and	Medium	Empowering

	manage birth control.		
Analysis; Displays an aggregated version of all past cycles, and also current one	Display aggregated data on past and current menstrual cycles. Use this to monitor trends and plan for future cycles.	Medium	Empowering
Content; Displays major categories such as, fertility, sex, menstruation, LGBTQIA+, birth control, issues & conditions, postpartum.	Display educational resources on fertility, sex, menstruation, LGBTQIA+, birth control, and reproductive health issues. Use this to learn more about reproductive health and wellness.	Medium	Empowering

Table 1. All identified features and functions have been ranked of various degrees of accessibility and empowerment.

Table 1-Ranking for the Accessibility column	
Rank	**Description**
N/A:	Not applicable
Easy	The feature or function was easy to find and use
Medium	The feature or function was somewhat difficult to find or use, but not excessively so
Difficult	The feature or function was very hard to find or use, or required a lot of effort to access

Table 1.1. The ranking system regarding the accessibility column in table 1.

Table 1-Ranking for the Empowerment Column	
Rank	**Description**
Empowering	A feature or function that is considered empowering would have a positive impact on female empowerment. For example, a feature that provides access to comprehensive and accurate information about reproductive health, or a function that allows users to track their menstrual cycle in a way that promotes understanding and control over their own bodies would be considered empowering.
Neutral	A feature or function that is considered neutral does not have a clear impact on female empowerment. This may be because the feature or function is not related to reproductive health or female empowerment, or because its impact is not clear or consistent.
Disempowering	A feature or function that is considered disempowering would have a negative impact on female empowerment. For example, a feature that reinforces gender stereotypes or promotes harmful attitudes towards women, or a function that restricts or limits a user's access to important reproductive health information or resources would be considered disempowering.

Table 1.2. The ranking system regarding the empowerment column in table 1.

Feature/Function	**Available in free-version?**
Register an account	Yes
Mode: Track your menstruation	Yes
Mode: Track your fertilization	No
Mode: Track your pregnancy	No
Calendar, displays different things the user *wants to track*	Yes
Track your spotting	Yes

Track your emotions	Yes
Track your pain	Yes
Track your sleep	Yes
Track your sexlife	Yes
Track your energy	Yes
Track your PMS	Yes
Track your menstrual protection	Yes
Track your mood	Yes
Track your social life	Yes
Track your cravings	Yes
Track your discharge	Yes
Track your skin	Yes
Track your hair	Yes
Track your weight	Yes
Track your digestion	Yes
Track your stool	Yes
Track your temperature	Yes
Track your training	Yes
Track your meditation	Yes
Track your freetime	Yes
Track your partying	Yes
Track your pregnancy or ovulation tests	Yes
Track your medical appointments	Yes
Track your medicines	Yes
Track your cramps	Yes
Track your contraceptive pill	Yes
Track your hormonal IUD	Yes

Track your contraceptive -injection	Yes
Track your contraceptive implant	Yes
Track your contraceptive-patch	Yes
Track your contraceptive-ring	Yes
Graphical display showing; how many days left of the cycle, when the next one will be, when the predicted ovulation will occur and when the user is most fertile	Yes
Settings; Show fertile days, accept/decline options of how Clue handles your data	Yes
Calendar; Displays different colors that symbolize different aspects of reproductive health such as menstruation and ovulation for example	Yes
Analysis; Displays an aggregated version of all past cycles, and also my current one	Yes, but Clue Plus promises insight into unique cycle patterns and experiences which indicates that the analysis feature in the free version does not provide that
Content; Displays major categories such as, fertility, sex, menstruation, LGBTQIA+, birth control, issues & conditions, postpartum.	Yes, but only to view the categories and not the actual content or text

Table 2. All identified features and functions with information if available for non-paying users.

Talk-aloud Method		
Where in the application	**What did you say**	**Reflection**
First page when opening application for the first time	They say that you can now live synced with your cycle, which seems promising	

The calendar page, where the user states when the menstruation began	As a male, it seems not to be an application directed for me, but perhaps for women and couples?	Accurate, it seem to be directed towards women or couples as they could benefit from the insight the application may provide
Page after registering an account	It suggests me to try out the premium version for free for seven days	This makes me think that the full utilization of what the application can provide requires a subscription
Page after registering an account	I tried to find where to close the advertisement, scrolled to the bottom and up. Then found a cross at the top, I just did not see it	The motivation is to make a profit from the user in exchange for better provided service. But again money, since it was not easy to exit that interaction.
The cycle page, when logged in	At the top, there is the option to try the premium version for free	The motivation may be to make a profit from the user in exchange for better provided service.
When press the button “Click to start tracking” and the available options are shown	The enormous amount of options available for the user, and the level of detail some options allow seem to be unnecessary and possibly worrying	The large quantity of options to input data, on a possibly daily basis can be worrying. Lots of the data can be used in the prediction of the menstrual cycle, but some can be perceived to be intrusive. It can also set a possible unwelcome standard for what activities are available depending on the user and their lifestyle. Having sex for example. But again, it can be quite relevant to reproductive health.
When press the button “Click to start tracking” and the available options are shown	The many options available in the feature “track your sexlife” bothers me, why would the app need to know if	Here is an example of what made me react. Why would it be beneficial for the user to register, or the application to have

	you used your fantasy, sextoys or just hands?	access to - if the user masturbated with the use of sex toys or their hands?
When press the button “Click to start tracking” and the available options are shown	The symbols are straightforward, good and understandable.	The symbols seemed to be carefully chosen and neutral while still conveying the meaning.
When press the button “Click to start tracking” and the available options are shown	The options of menstrual protection seem unnecessary, as they should not affect your biology?	Another example of something that made me react. The user should naturally be aware of what menstrual protection they prefer or do use. It does not affect anything biological or have an impact on the menstrual cycle. Seems more to be useful for future advertisement.
After some options have been selected, the tracking of how many days are left of the current cycle and the predicted date for the next one is shown	Seems to me not to be accurate, even if I was a woman, as the application states that I have three more days. It seems to me to have shown me the average number. It can be because I was not detailed enough of all the features available	In hindsight, it is understandable that the graphical representation is being general and not precise. This can be due to the lack of data provided.
Front Page -> Profile -> Settings -> Privacy Settings	There are two slide buttons, they are turned on - this allows them to collect my user data and use services from third-parties. The first slide-button is regarding “Advertisement purposes such as tracking or retargeting” and the second slide-button is regarding “Statistical- and analysis purposes, and improvement of the application”. At first sight, it seems	They state that they do not sell data, but the option being turned on when creating the application is odd. Especially considering that the first slide-button states that it is for advertisement purposes.

	strange but maybe it is reasonable at least with the second option.	
Profile Page -> Everywhere via that page	There are two design elements of similar design, where the user is advised to get Clue Plus - the premium version of the application. The impression so far of this application is that they want to earn money, and gather lots of data	They wish for users to buy a subscription to access Clue Plus.
Advertisement for upgrading to Clue Plus	There is a seven day free trial offered, the Clue also provides details regarding what they offer in the application and as a service provider	What is noteworthy is that if the user picks the 7 day trial, it seems to be followed by a 12 month subscription. This might lead to the possibility of a user forgetting to cancel, then needing to pay for 12 months.
Profile Page -> Everywhere via that page	I have not found any option to delete my account	It does exist, of course. But I did not find it.
Calendar page on the app	It seems good, it displays different colors which symbolize different things such as menstruation or ovulation.	Informative and easy to overview, IF, the user does not track too many things due it being hard to follow what color represents what
Analysis page on the app	It seems as the user would benefit for continuous use of this application as the analysis page is not that interesting when there is not much data to analyze	Easy to overview, can be a powerful analytical tool to get insight into what the user cares about. Provided that the user does continue to provide data.
Content page on the app	This seems to be rich with information ranging from fertility, sex and menstruation to LGBTQIA+, birth control and postpartum.	Very informative, written by experts as stated by Clue themselves. But it’s not accessible to the userwithout purschasing a subscription to Clue Plus.

	In postpartum for example, it ranges from week one to six. But, you need Clue Plus to access anything on the content page.	

Table 3. A collection of when the author reacted to something displayed on the application Clue, using the method Talk Aloud.

Image 1. The frontpage after logging in.

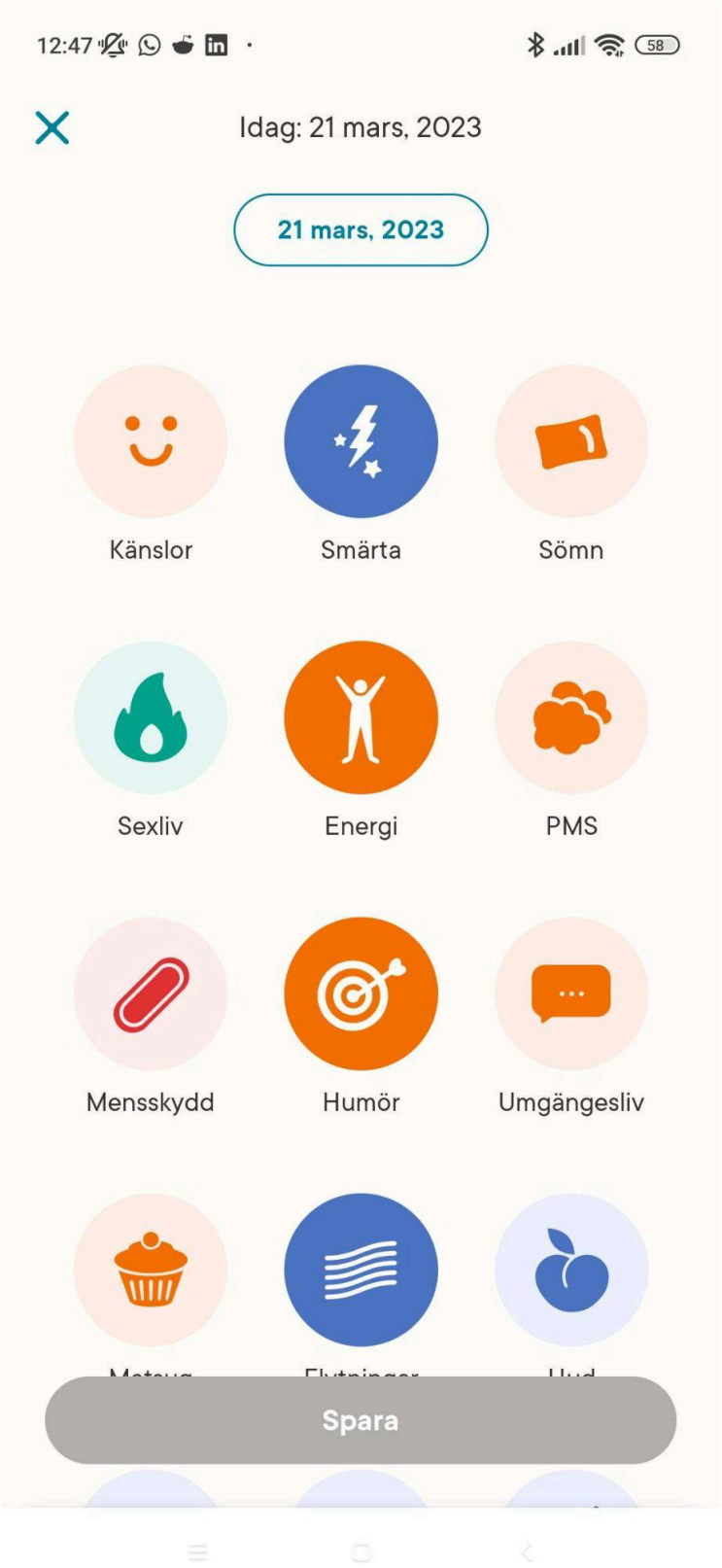

Image 2. The page where users choose what bothers them or what they find relevant to share with the application.

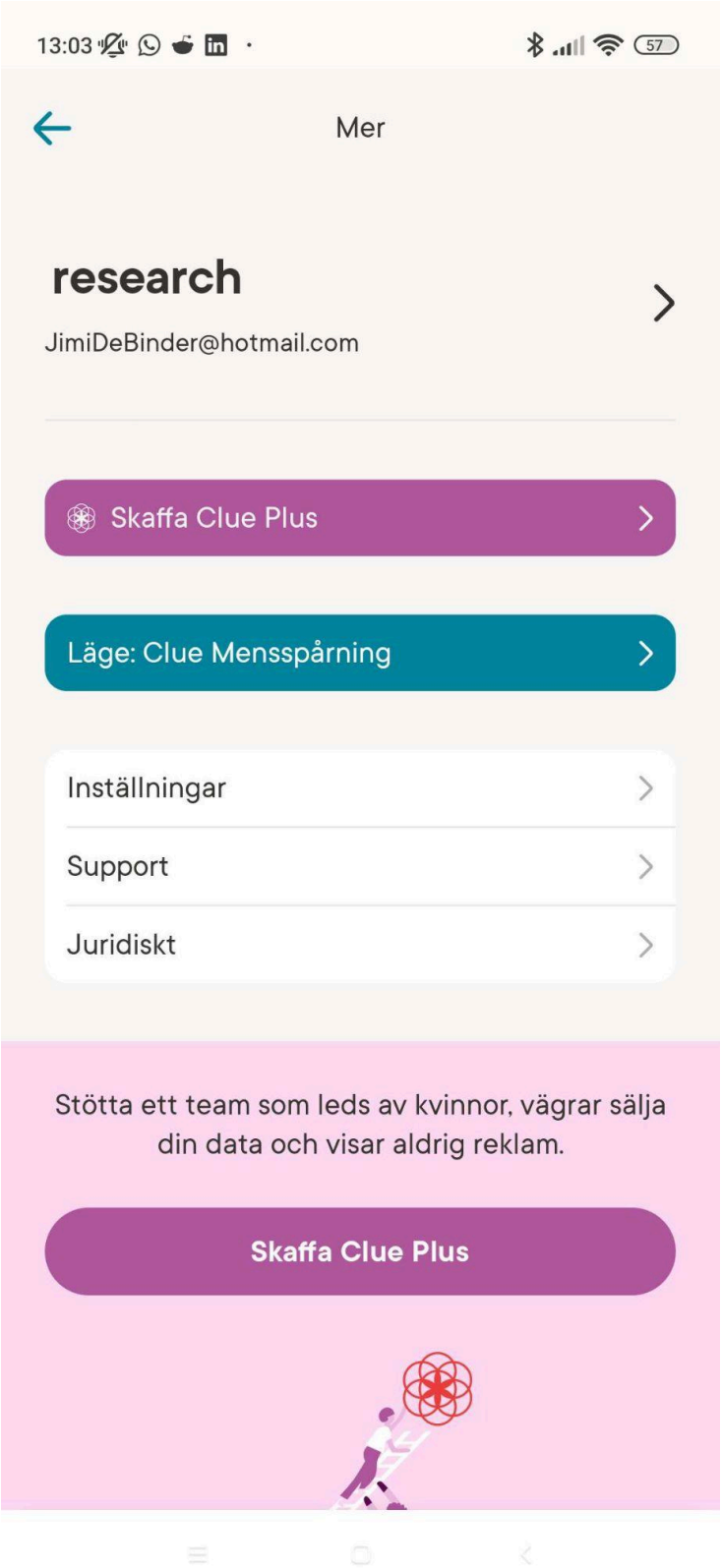

Image 3. The profile page.

Image 4. The calendar page, visualizing different dates with different colors depending on what the user has previously provided the application with.

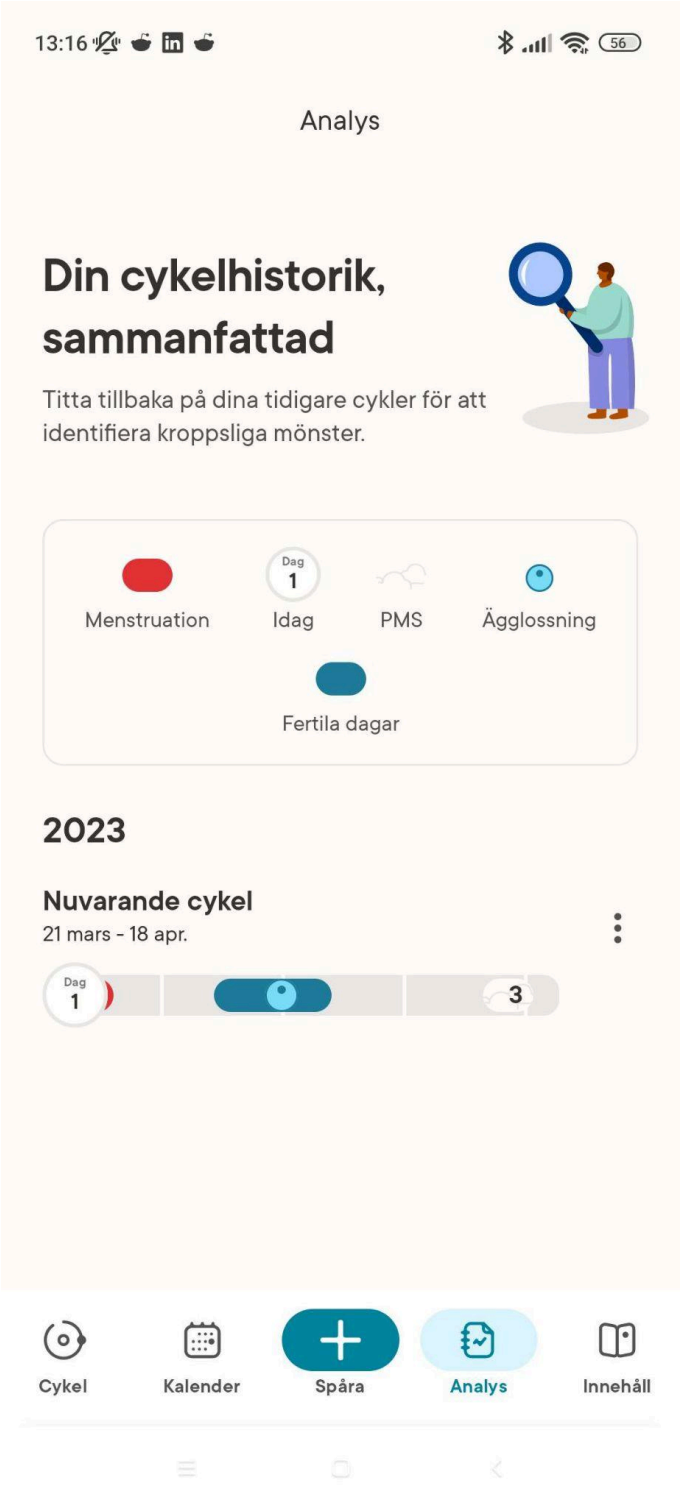

Image 5. The page for analyzing the users data.

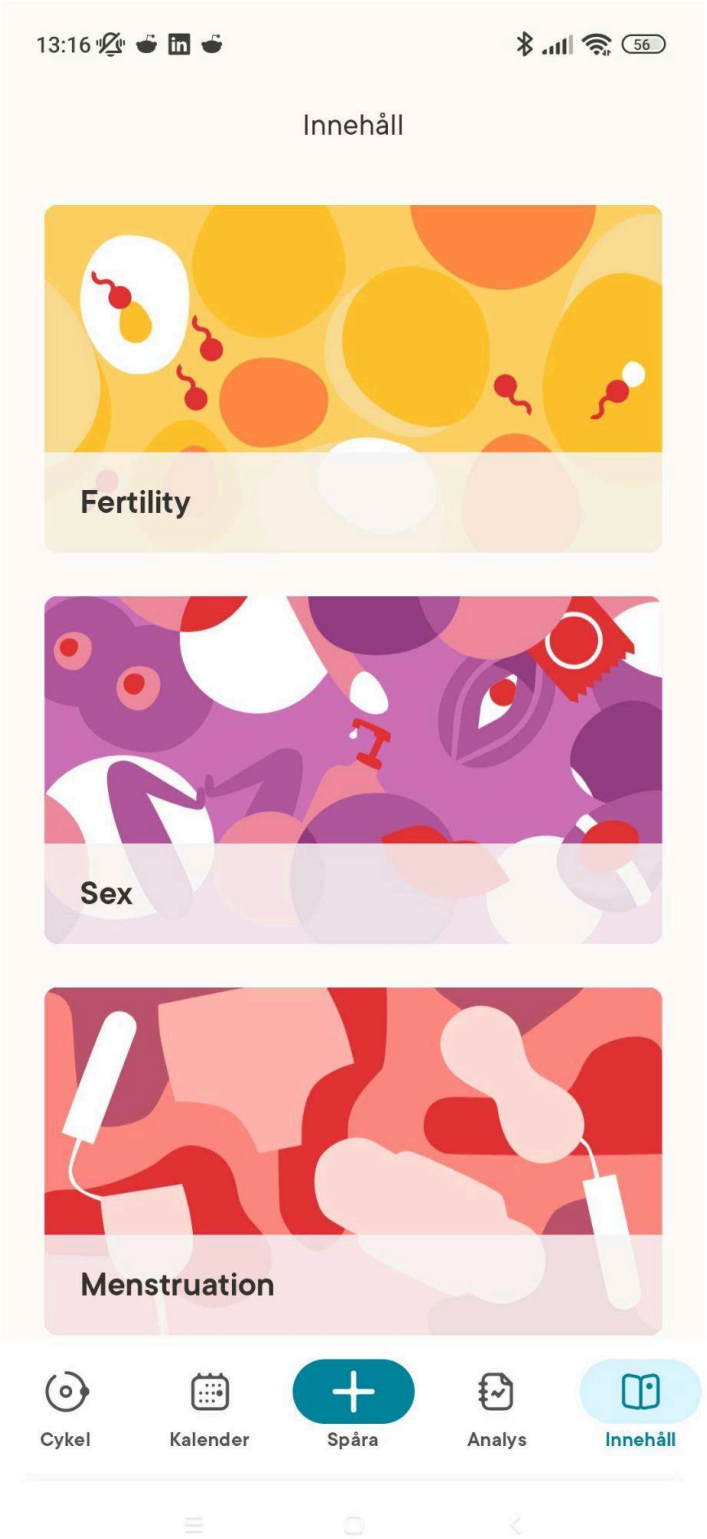

Image 6. The page regarding the content that users can access, if they have Clue Plus.

Image 7. The advertisement for upgrading to Clue Plus, this one specifically offers you seven days for free.

Image 8. A continuation of image 7, where they provide information regarding their unique qualities as a service provider.

Image 9. A continuation of the images 7 and 8. Here are the price options.